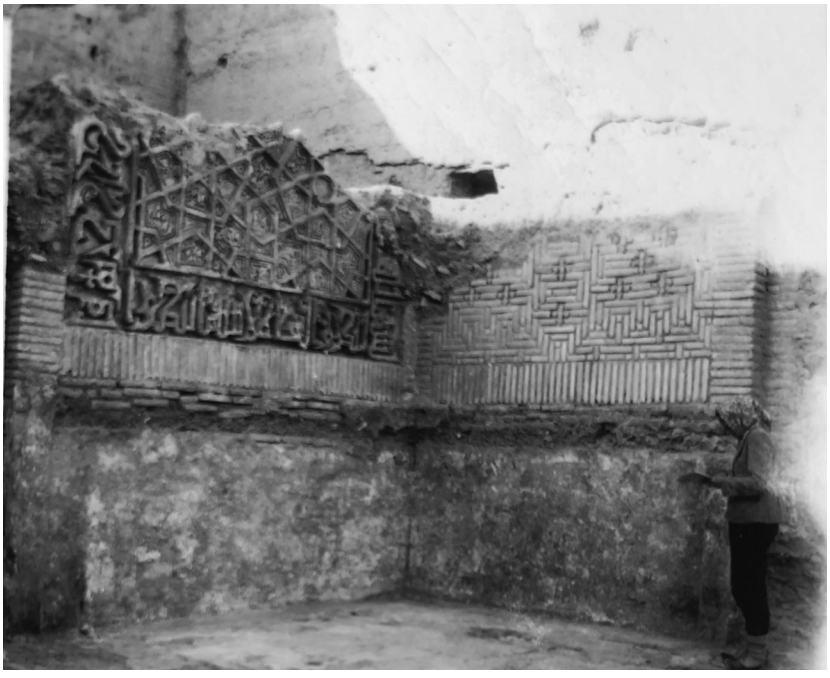


Figure 5.25 *Lashkari Bazar, South Palace, Audience Hall I, detail of stucco revetments (photograph* c. *1950s). © Courtesy of Musée des Arts Asiatiques-Guimet, Paris.*

whole (Figure 5.14).[51] It thereby exemplified and made real the ceremonial power that the Ghaznavid sultans had wielded as part of Perso-Islamic kingly comportment, which helped them to retain command of an empire with both westward *and* eastward ambitions. The Hall's gateway location over the vast complex of the South Palace (Figure 5.14); its lavish decoration (Figures 5.25 and 5.26), including a noteworthy epigraphic program and the famous frescoes of courtly figures in procession; and its commanding vistas over the Helmand (Figures 5.27 and 5.28) all surely instantiated an even grander and encompassing notion of kingship than thus far experienced by Mu'izz al-Din at the court of his uncle at Bamiyan, and that of his older brother at Firuzkuh – and we recall that he had spent a year in Sistan at the court of Malik Shams al-Din Nasri (see above in this chapter).[52] Mu'izz al-Din's conquests of Ghazna and Lashkari Bazar, then, personified the proverbial shoes he would have to fill if he also had aspirations of extensive dominions radiating in various directions from Zabul–Zamindawar (maps, pp. xv and xvi).

All of these indications of a transition toward a court-based and possibly more sedentist lifestyle for the newly titled Shansabani sultan of Ghazna collectively create a stark contrast to the absence of palatial architecture at Firuzkuh. Such a divergence is not unprecedented, however: at